THE PIANO BUTLER · LEVEL BOOK

Beginner

Nine rooms: sitting and hands, the keyboard, fingering, the staff, the beat, notes and rests, loud and soft, and games for your ears. Read each room, listen to it in the app, then practise.

THE ROOMS

1 · Posture and hand shape

2 · The keyboard

3 · Fingering

4 · The staff and the clefs

5 · Pulse, tempo and the bar

6 · Notes: crotchet and minim

7 · Notes: three beats and the semibreve

8 · Loud and soft

9 · Ear training

BEGINNER · ROOM 1

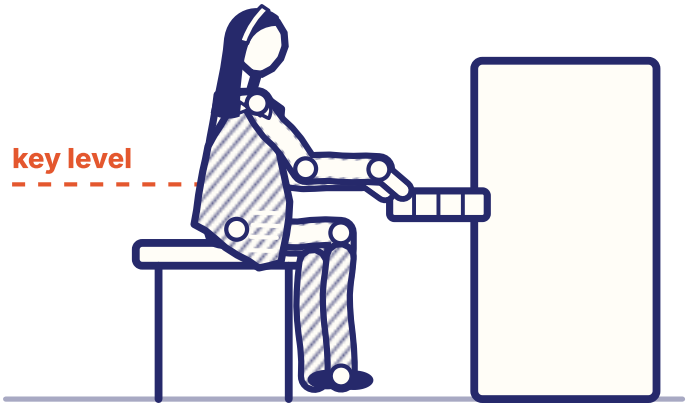
Posture and hand shape

More in the Handbook, pp. 18–20

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

Sit tall, forearms level with the keys, a round hand on the fingertips: then let the arm's weight do the work.

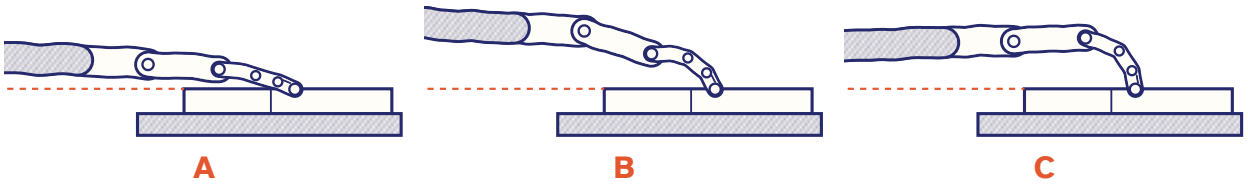


1. **forearms level with the keys**
   wrist neither dropped nor lifted
2. **elbows a little in front of you**
   not pinned to your sides
3. **sit on the front half of the stool**
   opposite Middle C
4. **feet flat on the floor**
   the right foot near the pedal
5. **back tall, shoulders loose**
   lean a little towards the keys

Tall back, level arms, flat feet

EXAMPLE 1

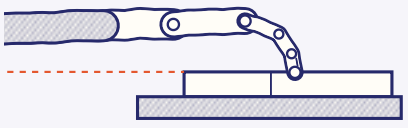
Which hand is round?



1. **Look at the knuckles:** up, or sunk in?
2. **Look at the tips:** does the finger stand on its tip?
3. **Which hand** could play all day?

C: knuckles up, curved fingers, standing on the tips. A is flat; B's knuckle has caved in.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



The ball test.

Hold a small ball or an orange, then put the hand on the keys without changing its shape. That is your playing hand.

BEGINNER · ROOM 1 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Finger numbers

★☆☆

Write the number of each finger. They are the same in both hands. The first is done.

FINGER	NUMBER	FINGER	NUMBER
thumb	1	ring finger	
index finger		little finger	
middle finger			

2 Too low, too high, or right?

★★☆

Write too low, too high or right.

WHAT YOU SEE	THE STOOL IS
The elbows are well below the keys; the forearms go uphill.	too low
The forearms are level with the keys.	
The elbows are above the keys; the wrists drop down to them.	

3 The 30-second check

★☆☆

Every time you sit down to practise, check each line and tick a circle. One circle per day.

	MON TO SUN
Stool: forearms level with the keys	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○
Body: front half of the stool, feet flat	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○
Shoulders: lifted, then dropped	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○
Hands: round, knuckles up	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○
Breathe out, then play	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

BEGINNER · ROOM 2

The keyboard

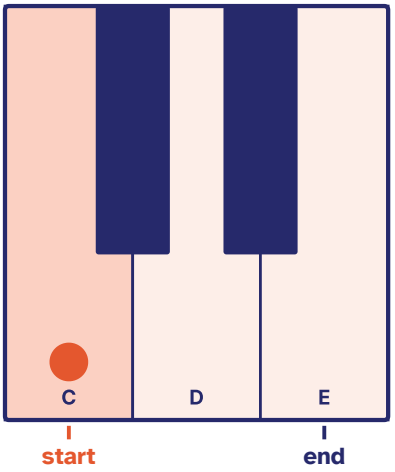
More in the Handbook, pp. 22–26

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

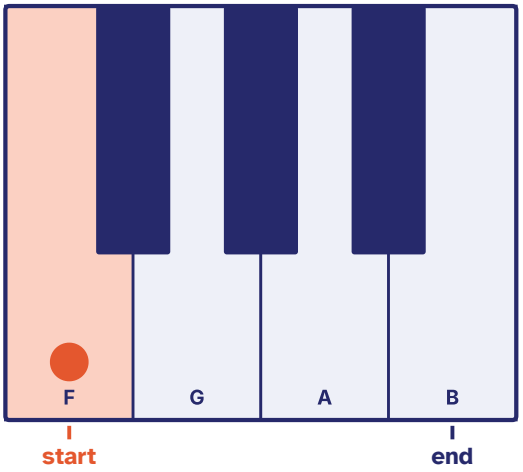
Two black keys: start on C. Three black keys: start on F. Then walk on.

2 black keys: C D E



on the piano E and F touch

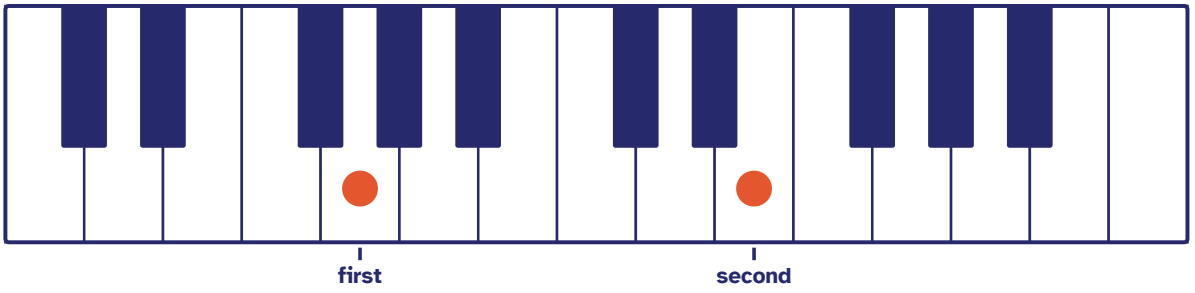
3 black keys: F G A B



Pulled apart: each family has a first key (start) and a last key (end)

EXAMPLE 1

Higher or lower?



1. **Find the two red keys.**
2. **Which one is further right?**
3. **Right means higher:** play both and listen.

The second note is **higher**: it is to the right. Left is always lower, right always higher.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

2 · 3

Find every group of two.

Start at the bottom of the piano. Touch each group of two black keys with fingers 2 and 3, all the way to the top. Then do the same with the groups of three.

BEGINNER · ROOM 2 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Twos and threes

★☆☆

Circle every group of two black keys and every group of three. How many of each?

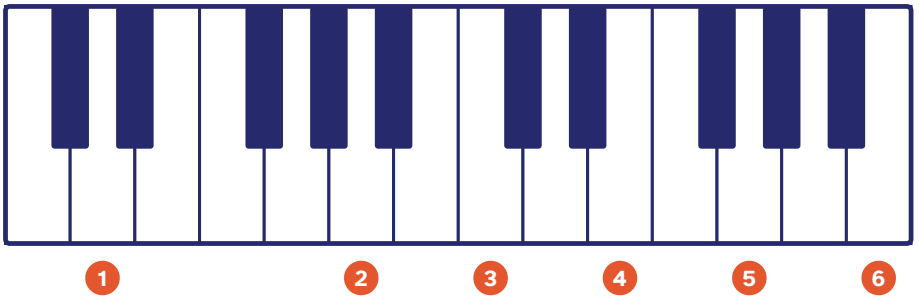


groups of two ☐ groups of three ☐

2 Name the keys

★☆☆

Find the group, then its first key, then walk on. Write the letter name of each numbered key. The first is done.



1 D 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐

3 Round and round

★☆☆

Seven letters, A to G, then A again. Write the next three letters: going up on the left, going down on the right. The first is done.

GOING UP	GOING DOWN
E F G **A B C**	C B A **G F E**
F G A	B A G
A B C	D C B

BEGINNER · ROOM 3

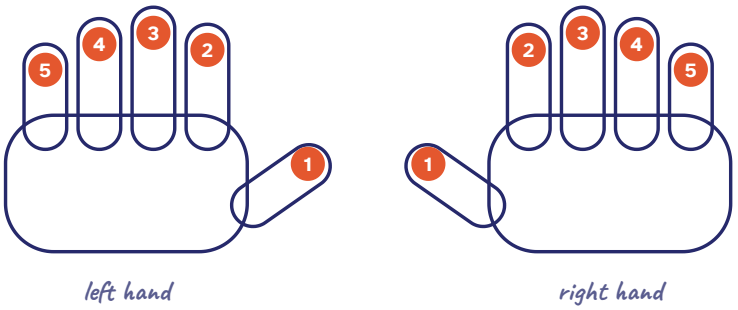
Fingering

More in the Handbook, pp. 163–164

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

Thumbs are 1 in both hands. Choose a fingering once, write it in, keep it.



Thumbs are 1 in both hands

EXAMPLE

Which finger plays the E?

1	?	?	?	?
C	D	E	F	G

1. **Right hand:** thumb on C.
2. **One finger** for each key: C D E F G.
3. **Count up** to E: 1, 2, 3.

Finger **3**. In this position the fingers 1 2 3 4 5 play C D E F G.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

1	2	3	4	5
C	D	E	F	G

Five fingers, five keys.

Thumb on C. Play C D E F G and back, saying the finger numbers out loud.

BEGINNER · ROOM 3 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Five-finger position ★☆☆

Right-hand thumb on C, left-hand little finger on C: write the finger for each note. The first is done.

	C	D	E	F	G
right hand	1				
left hand					

2 Which finger? ★☆☆

Right hand, thumb on C. Write the finger that plays each note. The first is done.

NOTE	E	G	D	F	C
Finger	3				

3 Play it ★☆☆

Play C D E F G up and down with each hand, saying the finger numbers. Tick a circle each day.

BEGINNER · ROOM 4

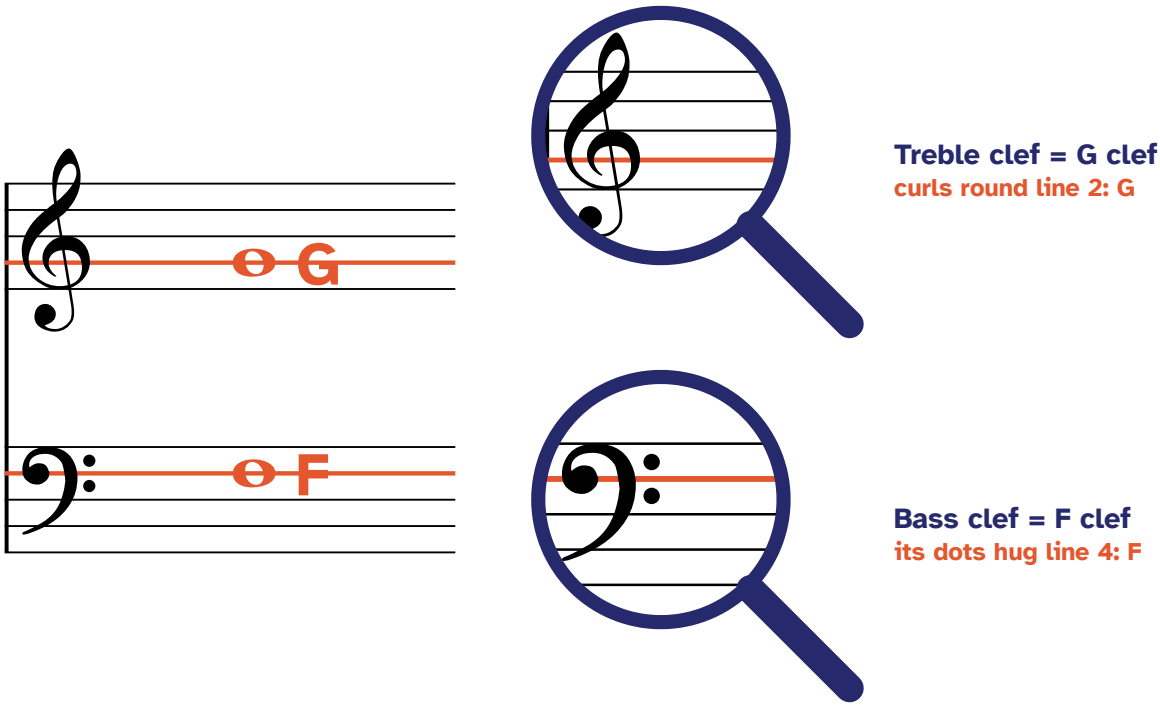
The staff and the clefs

More in the Handbook, pp. 27–28

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

The treble clef curls round G; the bass clef's two dots hug F.



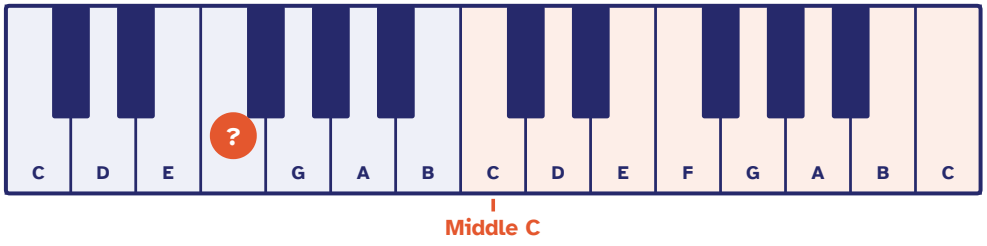
Treble clef = G clef
curls round line 2: G

Bass clef = F clef
its dots hug line 4: F

The treble clef is the G clef: it curls round G · the bass clef is the F clef: its dots hug F

EXAMPLE

Which staff is this key written on?



1. **Find Middle C.**
2. **Is the ? to its left or right?** Left is lower: the blue half.
3. **Low keys go on the bass staff**, high keys on the treble staff.

The **?** is below Middle C, so it is written on the **bass staff**, usually for the left hand.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Draw the two clefs.

Trace a treble clef in the air, curling round line 2 (G). Then a bass clef, its dot starting on line 4 (F).

BEGINNER · ROOM 4 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 The clefs ★☆☆

Write the name of each clef and the note it marks.

CLEF	NAME	IT MARKS THE LINE FOR
		
		

2 Line or space? ★☆☆

Circle line or space, then write its number (counted from the bottom). The first is done.

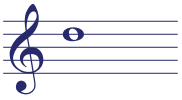


line · space

1



line · space



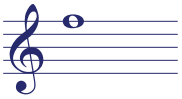
line · space



line · space



line · space



line · space

3 The grand staff ★☆☆

Complete each sentence.

Piano music joins two staves with a _____ .

The _____ staff is on top, usually for the _____ hand.

The _____ staff is below, usually for the _____ hand.

Between them, on a short line of its own, sits _____ .

BEGINNER · ROOM 5

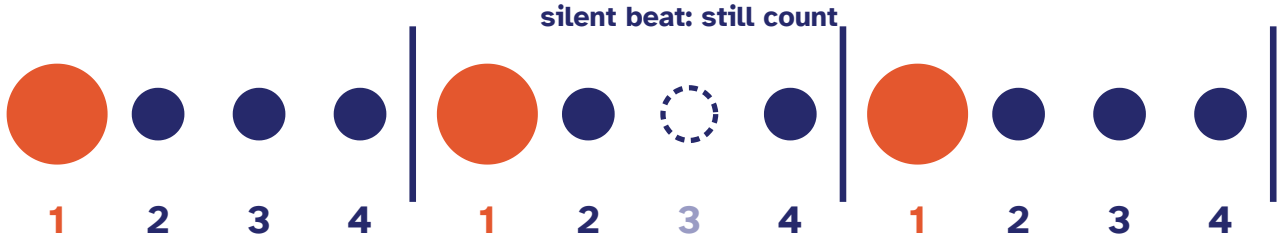
Pulse, tempo and the bar

More in the Handbook, pp. 50–52

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

The beat is steady, like a heartbeat. Bar lines group the beats, and beat 1 of every bar is the strongest.



Beat 1 of every bar is the strongest

EXAMPLE

Feel the beat before you play



1. **Set a metronome** to 96: 96 beats a minute.
2. **Listen first:** let one bar go by, counting 1 2 3 in your head.
3. **Step in** on the next beat 1, like stepping onto a moving escalator.

The first note lands **on the beat**, not a guess.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Hand on your heart. Tap the beat.

Say “1 2 3 4” with your taps, 1 a little louder. Keep going for ten seconds without slowing down.

BEGINNER · ROOM 5 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 How many beats in each bar?

★☆☆

Count the dots between the bar lines. The first is done.



3







2 Add the bar lines

★★☆

Beat 1 is the big coral dot. Draw a bar line just before each one (the first is done).



3 Clap and count

★★☆

Set a metronome to 60. Clap on beat 1, tap your knees on 2, 3 and 4, and count aloud. Keep going for a whole minute. Tick a circle each day.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

BEGINNER · ROOM 6

Notes: crotchet and minim

More in the Handbook, pp. 53–55

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

A crotchet lasts one beat; a minim lasts two: play on one count and hold through the next. Each has a rest just as long: count it, but do not play.

2 minims



4 crotchets



EXAMPLE

How many beats in this bar?



1. **Minim:** 2 beats.
2. **Crotchet:** 1. **Crotchet rest:** 1, silent.
3. **Add them up.**

2 + 1 + 1 = **4 beats**: a full bar, with one beat of silence.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Clap, then press and hold.

Clap four crotchets, counting 1 2 3 4. Then play C as a minim: press on 1, hold through 2. Do it twice to fill the bar.

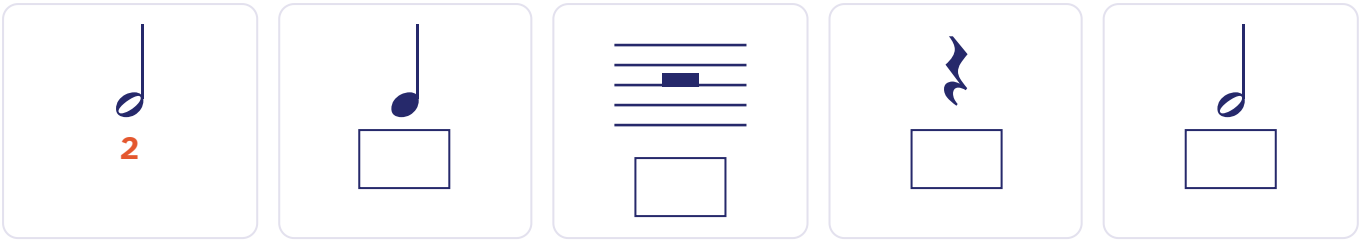
BEGINNER · ROOM 6 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 One beat or two?

★☆☆

Write 1 or 2 under each. The first is done.



2 Fill the bar

★★☆

Four beats in each bar. Write the missing note: crotchet or minim. The first is done.



minim





3 Play and count

★★☆

Say the counts out loud and play: a crotchet is play, a rest is shh. Write 1 2 3 4 under the bar.



BEGINNER · ROOM 7

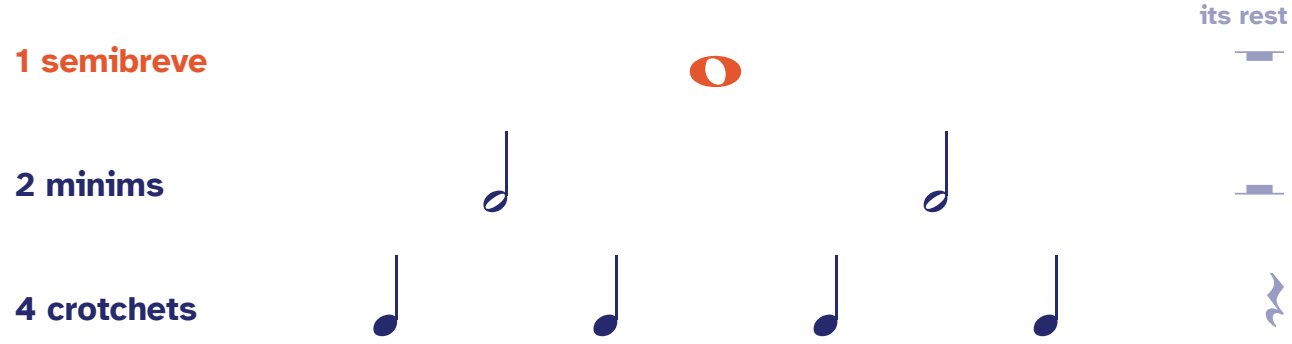
Notes: three beats and the semibreve

SCAN TO LISTEN

More in the Handbook, pp. 53–55

THE SECRET

A dot adds half: a dotted minim lasts three beats. A semibreve lasts four, a whole bar of four; its rest hangs from the fourth line, like a coat.



Each note splits into two of the next

EXAMPLE

Which note fills the bar?



1. **A bar of three:** count 1 2 3.
2. **A bar of four:** count 1 2 3 4.
3. **Dotted minim** 2 + 1; **semibreve** 4.

Three beats: the **dotted minim**. Four beats: the **semibreve**.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Hold for three, then four.

Press C and hold for 1 2 3, swaying like a waltz. Then press again and hold for all four beats, listening to the very end.

BEGINNER · ROOM 7 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Name, beats and rest

★☆☆

Fill in the table. The first row is done.

NOTE	NAME	BEATS	ITS REST
	semibreve	4	
			
			
			–

2 Waltz time

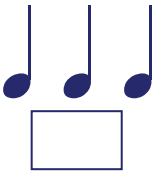
★★☆

Each bar has three beats. Count 1 2 3 and play each bar. Write how many notes it has. The first is done.



1





3 Coat or hat?

★☆☆

The semibreve rest hangs like a coat; the minim rest sits like a hat. Write coat or hat.



coat







BEGINNER · ROOM 8

Loud and soft

More in the Handbook, pp. 76–78

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

Dynamics tell you how loud to play: *p* is soft, *f* is loud. The weight of your arm makes the change, not the speed.



pp	*p*	*mp*	*mf*	*f*	*ff*
very soft	soft	half soft	half loud	loud	very loud
pianissimo	***piano***	***mezzo-piano***	***mezzo-forte***	***forte***	***fortissimo***

Six steps from a whisper to a shout

EXAMPLE

Which is louder: mp or mf?

mp* · *mf

1. **m** means *mezzo*: half.
2. **p** soft, **f** loud.
3. **Half loud** beats half soft.

mf, half loud, is louder than *mp*, half soft.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

pp* → *ff

One note, six ways.

Play Middle C *pp*, then *p*, *mp*, *mf*, *f*, *ff*: six different steps, using the weight of your arm. Then come back down.

BEGINNER · ROOM 8 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Say it ★☆☆

Write the Italian name and what it means. The first row is done.

SIGN	NAME	MEANS
p	piano	soft
mf		
ff		
mp		
pp		
f		

2 Play it ★☆☆

Play Middle C six times: pp, p, mp, mf, f, ff. Six different steps? Tick a circle each day.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

3 Which is louder? ★☆☆

Circle the louder sign in each pair. The first is done.

PAIR	LOUDER
p · *f*	*f*
mp · *mf*	
pp · *p*	
f · *ff*	

BEGINNER · ROOM 9

Ear training

Listening games before the exams

SCAN TO PLAY

THE SECRET

Listen first, then play. Good ears make good fingers.

	GAME	WHAT YOU LISTEN FOR
1	**Low, middle or high?**	Is the sound low, in the middle or high?
2	**Same rhythm or different?**	Two rhythms: the same, or one small change?
3	**Same tune or different?**	Two little tunes: the same, or one note changed?
4	**Which way did it go?**	Three notes: going up, going down, or staying?
5	**Find the note**	Hear a note, then find it on the keys.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Sing before you play.

Before you play a note, sing it. Then play it and listen: were you right?

BEGINNER · ROOM 9 · PRACTISE

Practise

Away from the screen, with a grown-up or your teacher. Tick a circle each time.

1 Floor, tummy or sky? ★☆☆

A grown-up plays one key: very low, in the middle, or very high. Eyes closed! Point to the floor, your tummy or the sky.

2 Copy-cat clap ★☆☆

A grown-up claps four beats. Clap it back exactly. Then swap: you clap, they copy. Was it the same?

3 Stairs up, stairs down ★☆☆

A grown-up plays three keys next to each other, going up or going down. Show the way with your hand, then sing it.